

GG, K, and K'

Gg, k and k' are three of the five back of the throat sounds which are found in Witsuwit'en but not English. Question: what are the other two (which we have talked about in some detail), and can you pronounce them?

K vs. GG

Gg and **k** have already been presented. We contrasted **gg** with **g** and also **gg** with **gh**. We similarly compared **k** with **c**.

Now we are going to compare **gg** and **k**. It's hard to find words that are the same or nearly so except for **gg** vs. **k** because **gg** is rare before the vowels **a** and **o**, does not occur before **ë** or **iy**, and does not occur word-finally. **K**, on the other hand, is rare before the vowels **ï**, **u** and **e**. Furthermore, for some speakers, remember that **gg** is normally pronounced like **k**: that is, these two consonants are not different for such speakers. But for other speakers, the following words show the difference between **k** and **gg**:

kecip 'spoon'	ggec 'only, exclusively', as in:
	dicin ggec 'only (of) wood'
keyikh 'village, reserve'	nilggeyh 'he/she is running around'
yudilhkit 'he/she asked him/her'	yilh hozggit 'he/she squashed it'
skiy 'my husband'	siggï 'it dried'
ku' 'puppy'	gguh 'deadfall'
kunye 'Indian hellebore'	ggunek 'hummingbird'

Examples of K'

K' is like **gg** except that since it is one of the sounds written with ' , it is produced with a glottal stop, pressure build-up and then a little explosion. Here are some examples of words that contain **k'**:

k'a	'bullet'
k'az	'file, rasp'
k'iy	'birch'
k'on	'fish eggs, roe'
k'idikh	'still, (not) yet'
bik'it	'on it (horizontal surface)'
bik'iz	'half, one side of it'
wik'iz	'coldness'
hilk'it	'it's swelling up'

k' must be followed by a vowel. **k'** does not occur at the end of a syllable (word-finally).

K vs. K'

K and **k'** can be followed by the same vowels, so there are a fair number of words which are the same or very similar except for **k** vs. **k'**.

bikiy 'her husband'	bik'iy 'her hip, pelvic area'
ku' 'puppy'	biyin k'u' 'his/her hunched back'
ndu bika? 'why, what for?'	bik'a' 'his/her bullet(s)'

yilh kay ‘it dawned’
 bikë ‘his/her foot, footwear’
 hëlkit ‘he/she slipped’
 këledzec ‘tiptoe’
 yunkët ‘he/she bought it’

k’ay ‘now, recently’
 bik’ëhin ‘his/her younger child/sibling’
 hilk’it ‘it’s swelling up’
 k’ëltay ‘inner bark’
 yïnk’ët ‘he/she had sex with him/her’⁸

K’ vs. GG

These two consonants can be hard to distinguish because **gg**, as a back-of-the-throat sound, has a noisy release that can sound like the glottal release in **k’**. Neither consonant occurs at the end of a word. But contrasts are few because **k’** (like **k**) is rare before the vowels **ï**, **u** and **e**, and **gg** is rare before the vowels **a** and **o**, and does not occur before **ë** or **iy**.

sk’iy ‘my hip’
 wik’in k’it ‘burned area’
 k’inih ‘sap’
 k’is ‘alder; or’
 bik’iz ‘half, one side of it’
 wik’iz ‘coldness’
 yik’ësde ‘he/she represents him/her’

siggï ‘it dried’
 ggin ‘that person’
 gginï, ngginï ‘those people’
 yizggis ‘he/she sprained it’
 nisggiz ‘I’m leading him/her around (by arm)’
 weggiz ‘mountain pass, valley between hills’
 yigges ‘he/she is scratching it (hard)’

E and EY

Witsuwit’en has a contrast between **e** and **ey**, where **ey** is like a sequence of the vowels **e** and **ï**. In English there is no contrast between **e** and **ey** (in American and Canadian English the vowel in this area of the vowel space is closer to **ey**), so for learners of Witsuwit’en it is important to be aware of the difference.

Examples of e (review)

c’itne
 C’itne
 hone
 tēzye
 so’ hitēzye
 winiilhye
 ’akw’is desisyē

‘he/she is drinking something’
 ‘Gitksan person’
 ‘he/she moved, changed residence’
 ‘he/she left (walking)’
 ‘he/she made a good announcement’
 ‘he/she won’
 ‘I almost died’

Examples of ey

ey occurs in fewer words than **e** in Witsuwit’en, but the first example below is a very common word:

’ey
 dey
 c’ide’ dey hoz(d)li’

‘it’
 ‘starvation’, as in:
 ‘a long time ago people starved’

⁸yïnk k’ët ‘mossy place’ is a compound, thus written with a space between the two meaningful parts, but is basically pronounced the same as yïnk’ët ‘he/she had sex with him/her’.

The second vowel of the following words is **ey** for some speakers, **iy** for others:

dīnc'ey ~ dīnc'iy	'four'
yizc'ey ~ yizc'iy	'he/she shot it once'
nitcey ~ nitciy	'he/she is being transported'

E vs. EY

Now here are some words which are similar except for the **e** vs. **ey** difference:

hine 'he/she/it is alive'	hiney 'animal' (lit. 'that which is alive')
'et sile 'they (objects) are there'	ts'iley 'there are many of us'
netl'adide 'he/she sat down'	nec'inisdey 'he/she is full'
wesiy 'lynx'	'et weydeh 'he/she isn't sitting there'
welew 'there is nothing'	weylīh 'he/she/it is not':
	dinī weylīh 'it isn't a person'
deninle 'you brought them (things) inside'	deyninle 'he/she brought them (things) inside'
nedist'ay 'I found it for myself'	neydit'ay 'he/she found it for himself/herself'
wibedīn'ay	wibeydīn'ay
'you brought it (e.g. hat) around the corner'	'he brought it around the corner'

H (review)

Witsuwit'en **h** is basically pronounced the same way as English *h*. Question: do you remember the big distributional difference between Witsuwit'en **h** and English *h*? (Where can Witsuwit'en **h** occur that English *h* does not?)

Before a vowel:

hēkw	'go ahead'
hida	'moose'
hinic	'language'
hots	'from there'
honye	'he/she left, went out'
hanye	'he/she came up, out'

At the end of a word:

tsēh	'first'
'anīh	'come'
'it'ah	'he/she is working'
bih	'dad' (talking to him)
diguh	'mosquito'
widzīh ~ midzīh	'caribou'

Before a consonant:

dzīhtēl	'lumber'
c'iyehs'iy	'bird'
bik'ēhs'iy	'its gills'
witsēhde'	'previously'

'it'ahnī
Gguhlat

'workers'
C'ilhts'ėkhyu chief name

H vs. nothing

sendeh 'sit' (command to one person)
weugeh 'he/she isn't shy'
weylih 'he/she is not'
'et weykah 'it (e.g. table) isn't there'

sende 'you're sitting'
unge 'he/she is shy'
nli 'he/she is'
'et wika 'for that reason'

YH

Examples of YH

Witsuwit'en **yh** is similar to the pronunciation of English *h* in the word *hue*. However, in Witsuwit'en **yh** basically only occurs at the end of a word or before a consonant-initial suffix.⁹

yh can be preceded by any vowel except **i** (and maybe not **ė**). The most common preceding vowels are **a i e**.

dits'iyh
misiyh
c'ekayh
Simayh
Simuyh
bineyh
nilggeh
'oh lhiyeyh

'it's rough'
'thank you'
'he/she is dipnetting'
C'ilhts'ėkhyu chief name
C'ilhts'ėkhyu chief name
'his/her clothes, its (bird's) plumage'
'he/she is running around'
'he/she usually walks by there'

YH vs. H

Since both **yh** and **h** occur at the end of a word, compare the following:

ten'ayh 'carry it'
neyh 'clothes'
tiyeyh 'he/she is leaving (on foot)'
'et hideyh 'he/she usually sits there'

'ent'ah 'you're working, work!'
ts'ineh 'orphan'
nėwewilyeh 'he/she isn't wise'
'et weydeh 'he/she isn't sitting there'

YH vs. Y

y and **yh** are very similar sounds. Both of these sounds occur at the end of the word after the same kinds of vowels, so it is important not to confuse these sounds. Compare the following:

'ayh 'snowshoe(s)'
neon'ayh 'find out'
yikayh 'dawn'
yits'iyh 'he/she is pinching him/her'
liztiyh 'knife'

bi'ay 'his/her snowshoe(s)'
neon'ay 'you, he/she found out'
willkay 'next day'
ts'iy 'cottonwood; boat'
bitiy 'its handle'

⁹There is one loanword exception, **Dihihi** 'Cree', where **yh** occurs before a vowel, but this word is not widely known.

ntelh'iyh 'sneak off'
 hanelkoyh 'vomit it out'
 nideyh 'he/she is dancing'

ntëlh'iy 'he/she sneaked off'
 haneyilkoy 'he/she vomited it out'
 dey 'starvation', as in
 dey hoz(d)li 'there was starvation'

Writing practice 5

_____	'stop it'
_____	'blood clot, gunshot meat'
_____	'dance apron'
_____	'bullet case'
_____	'alder; or'
_____	'in water'
_____	'he/she is awake'
_____	'gray jay, "camprobber"'
_____ or _____	'snow melted'
_____	'there is/are'
_____	'fifty cents'
_____	'Broman Lake'
_____	'in the middle'
_____	'let it fly off, it could fly off'
_____	'let him/her work, he/she could work'
_____	'sight (on gun)'
_____	'my sister'
_____	'he/she went uphill'
_____	'they're dancing'
_____	'he's asking him a trick question'
_____	'he asked him a trick question'
_____	'turn it (light) off, put it (fire) out'
_____	'we're going to go for huckleberries'

When you have finished, compare what you wrote with your neighbor and try to come to some agreement.

Answers to writing practice 5

deh
 dil
 khaz
 k'as
 k'is
 tot
 winih
 gguzih
 uzlit or uzdlit
 wini
 c'ik'iz
 C'iggiz
 c'edik
 tot'akh
 'ot'ah
 bini'iyh
 silhtëhts'iy
 hasiye
 hinideyh
 neyikayh
 neyinkay
 nenilhnekh
 digi haztadilh

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